

airports in Delhi and Hyderabad, among others. The first phase of the project has been completed under the public-private partnership (PPP) model at a revised sanctioned project cost of ₹2,870 crore.

Goa's primary airport in Dabolim belongs to the Indian Navy. Being a defence property attached to INS Hansa, the country's biggest naval airbase, it has constraints of time slots that restrict the operation of domestic and international flights to and from the airport to specified hours.

Moreover, the existing airport is oversaturated as it currently handles close to 8 million passengers per annum (MPPA) annually, against an actual capacity of 4.4 MPPA.

THREE MORE PHASES

With work on the first phase completed, Manohar International Airport can currently handle 4.4 MPPA. This will increase to 5.8 MPPA in the second phase, 9.4 MPPA in the third phase and finally to 13.1 MPPA in the fourth phase. The airport's capacity can be enhanced by nearly three times to handle up to 33 million passengers in case of a substantial increase in air traffic. Designed as a zero-carbon-footprint airport, it will join an elite club of green airports across the world.

Moreover, while it was initially proposed to shut down the existing Dabolim airport for civilian flights, the two airports will now operate in tandem to service their respective catchment areas in North and South Goa. And the government has left the distribution of traffic between the two airports to market dynamics.

"Less than 5 per cent of the traffic in Dabolim is international. Our objective is to have a mix of 20 per cent international and 80 per cent domestic. Accordingly, we will work with various international airlines to market our airport," says



Welcome, Tourists

- ▶ 18 check-in counters
- ▶ Four self-baggage drops
- ▶ 12 immigration and eight emigration counters
- ▶ A 25,000-MT temperature-controlled cargo terminal
- ▶ Capable of handling big aircraft like Airbus 380
- ▶ 3.5 km and 60 m wide runway
- ▶ Parallel taxiway with two rapid exits and six cross taxiways
- ▶ 14 parking bays, including aerobridges
- ▶ Adequate night parking facilities

R.V. Seshan, CEO of GGIAL, adding that passengers are willing to pay extra for a good ambience and service—and that will be the differentiator for Mopa airport.

Besides, the state—currently dependent on sectors like fishing, agriculture, tourism, pharmaceuticals, and mining—is looking to become an international hub of clean cutting-edge technologies

and industrial financial services on the lines of Dubai, Singapore, Hong Kong and Shanghai, further necessitating a major dedicated green-field international airport.

The airport—that was licensed by aviation regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) in October—will open for commercial operations from January 5, 2023. And leading Indian carriers have been quick to announce operations to and from the new airport.

IndiGo, the country's largest airline by fleet and market share, has announced 12 daily and a total of 168 weekly new flights to and from Mopa. This will be the low-cost carrier's (LCC) largest-ever new station launch, connecting the new airport to eight cities across India. Another LCC, Go First, has also announced 42 weekly flights to and from the airport. In a communication, Muscat-based Oman Air has announced that it will be shifting all its flights to Mopa from Dabolim starting January 1.

According to industry sources, more Indian and international carriers are expected to announce operations from Mopa in the coming months. This can mean only one thing—one of India's (and the world's) favourite holiday getaways has a new gateway for tourists. **BT**

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